

Final External Evaluation

Better Migration Management Programme Phase III

Executive Summary

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Commissioned by:

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The **East and Horn of Africa** is a region that serves as a point of origin, transit, and destination for migration. Here, migration arises from the adverse effects of climate change, conflict and instability, exacerbating socioeconomic challenges. Migrants in the region are highly vulnerable to exploitation, trafficking and other dangers related to migration in the region.¹

In 2016, the International Organization for Migration (IOM), alongside the British Council, CIVIPOL, GIZ and United Nations Office on Drugs and Crimes (UNODC), launched the **Better Migration Management (BMM)** programme in Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan and Uganda. The programme was funded by the European Union (EU) Trust Fund for Africa and the German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development. Since 2016, BMM has witnessed three phases.

The **overall objective** of BMM is to enable national authorities and institutions to manage safe, orderly and regular migration by applying a human rights-based approach and addressing human trafficking and smuggling of migrants. The programme comprises **three interconnected components**:

1. Strengthening migration governance to create legal frameworks for regionally coordinated migration management;
2. Supporting institutions to combat human trafficking and smuggling of migrants through integrated border governance; and
3. Protecting victims of trafficking and vulnerable migrants.

GIZ serves as the lead implementer of the programme, contracting IOM to implement activities under each of these three components. The **third phase** of the BMM programme commenced in October 2022 and is scheduled to conclude in March 2025, with the majority of activities completed by December 2024.

IOM commissioned an **independent final evaluation** to assess its contributions under Phase III. This evaluation, conducted by two external consultants, examines the **relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, impact, and sustainability** of IOM's interventions. It applies a theory-based approach, using the Theory of Change as a foundation and aligning with OECD DAC evaluation criteria and UN Evaluation Group (UNEG) norms and standards

The evaluation employed a **mixed-methods approach**, including desk research and key informant interviews. Desk research was conducted in two phases to ensure data triangulation, while **40 online interviews** were carried out with IOM staff, implementing partners, national government stakeholders, and civil society organizations.

Findings

The evaluation found that IOM's activities under the Phase III of BMM programme were **highly relevant** to the migration challenges in the East and Horn of Africa region, effectively addressing issues such as irregular migration, human trafficking, and weak institutional capacities. IOM's **adaptability to evolving contexts**, including conflicts and shifting political landscapes, ensured continued relevance. While alignment with initial

¹ <https://crisisresponse.iom.int/response/regional-migrant-response-plan-horn-africa-yemen-and-southern-africa-2024>

programme objectives remained strong, adjustments were necessary to accommodate changing government priorities.

IOM's Regional Office **effectively coordinated** IOM activities, ensuring smooth multi-country implementation and responsiveness through a well-structured management approach and country focal points. Internally, there was **strong coherence** with other IOM projects and frameworks which facilitated cost-sharing and expanded reach. The external coordination with other implementing partners fell primarily under GIZ responsibility as lead implementer of the BMM programme. In this regard, the dual role of GIZ as both a grant giver and an implementing partner added additional complexity in coordination and communication, but active and cooperative relationship between GIZ and the IOM Regional Office helped mitigate potential challenges.

IOM **largely met or exceeded Phase III programme targets**, contributing to strengthened migration governance, improved integrated border governance, and enhanced protection services for vulnerable migrants. Despite financial constraints, bureaucratic delays, and political instability, the programme effectively utilized resources, though initial delays led to spending pressures in later phases.

Sustainability remains a key concern, as continued reliance on donor funding poses risks to maintaining programme achievements. Ensuring national ownership and securing budget allocations will be critical in BMM Phase IV to sustain progress. The transition to BMM Phase IV presents an opportunity to reinforce sustainability measures, but risks remain if funding gaps and staffing disparities are not addressed. BMM Phase IV's lower budget and potentially stricter scope will make sustained investment and coordination even more critical.

The table below briefly summarizes key findings along the summarized evaluation questions:

Evaluation criteria and questions	Findings
Relevance	
Were IOM activities relevant to the needs of the countries and their stakeholders?	IOM activities under BMM Phase III were highly relevant as they addressed key migration challenges in the East and Horn of Africa, including irregular migration, human trafficking, weak migration governance, and limited protection mechanisms for vulnerable migrants. National stakeholders confirmed that IOM's interventions aligned with country priorities and regional migration frameworks.
Did IOM's activities remain valid and pertinent as originally planned, or were they subsequently modified?	While IOM's activities remained largely aligned with the original objectives, some modifications were made in response to emerging challenges. For instance, the conflict in Sudan necessitated a shift in focus toward strengthening border management in South Sudan, and national government priorities required adjustments, such as reallocating funding from the Migration Information and Data Analysis System (MIDAS) to an e-visa system in Djibouti.
Coherence	
To what extent IOM activities were internally aligned with other efforts of IOM?	IOM demonstrated strong internal coherence by integrating BMM activities with other migration-related programs, enabling cost-sharing and cross-program collaboration. Examples include co-funding initiatives and the alignment of BMM with the Regional Migrant Response Plan to ensure consistency in migration governance efforts.

To what extent IOM activities were externally aligned with efforts and organizations outside IOM?	IOM effectively coordinated with BMM implementing partners (GIZ, UNODC, CIVIPOL, and British Council) and aligned its work with regional actors. No significant overlaps were identified or mentioned by interview partners.
Effectiveness	
Did IOM deliver what it was supposed to do?	IOM met or exceeded most of its key performance indicators under the BMM Phase III results framework, particularly in enhancing migration governance, strengthening institutional capacities, and improving victim protection. Some outputs, such as training border officials and supporting policy development, surpassed initial targets.
What hindered the implementation of the programme and achievement of outcomes?	Several factors hindered implementation, including security challenges (e.g., armed conflicts and political instability in Ethiopia, and Somalia), delayed signing of the contractual agreement between IOM and GIZ, procurement bottlenecks, and changing government priorities that affected planned activities. Additionally, limited financial and human resources in some IOM country offices slowed down implementation.
Efficiency	
To what extent were IOM activities financially efficient?	While IOM successfully leveraged cost-sharing and maximized available resources, delayed contract signing at the start of Phase III led to low burn rates initially and a rush to spend remaining funds toward the end. Despite this, no major inefficiencies in resource allocation were identified.
To what extent was IOM efficient in terms of coordination and reporting?	Internal coordination was strong, with IOM's Regional Office for the East, Horn and Southern Africa as the management site, organising regular meetings between regional and country offices. Reporting mechanisms were well-structured and described as straightforward and manageable by staff despite frequent reporting requirements from the donor. Externally, some joint activities were conducted with other implementing partners, but further integration could be explored by GIZ as lead implementer to align partners' implementation timelines and create further synergies.
Impact	
What initial signs of impact of IOM activities can be noted?	IOM's activities have contributed to strengthened migration governance, with progress in policy development in several countries. Cross-border cooperation mechanisms, such as Inter-Agency Border Management Committees (IBMCs) in Somalia, have improved operational coordination. Additionally, community awareness campaigns and protection services have enhanced support for vulnerable migrants, though long-term impacts remain difficult to measure at this stage.
Sustainability	
To what extent the achievements of IOM activities are likely to be sustained long-term?	While IOM has helped institutionalize migration management through policies, training, and capacity-building, sustainability remains a concern. Many governments still rely on external funding, and gaps in national budgetary commitments threaten long-term program viability. The expected funding gap between BMM Phase III and IV could also disrupt continuity, potentially leading to staff turnover and loss of institutional knowledge.

Recommendations

To maintain and strengthen the effectiveness, efficiency, and sustainability of future IOM activities, especially under the BMM Phase IV, the evaluation recommends IOM to maintain its effective internal coordination structure with the Regional Office as the primary coordination and management site and maintain focal points in each BMM country to ensure localized responsiveness. Additionally, procurement and financial coordination should be reviewed to streamline processes and prevent delays.

To maintain programmatic momentum, transition plans should be developed to minimize staffing disruptions between programme phases, and multi-year funding commitments should be sought from donors to enhance stability. Based on experience from previous phases, IOM should anticipate potential contractual delays and changing national priorities during BMM Phase IV and plan its budgetary spending accordingly, to prevent spending pressures at the end of the project cycle.

To promote sustainability, national governments should gradually take on greater ownership and responsibility for migration governance efforts. A co-funding model could be introduced, where IOM contributes resources while national governments also commit financial or personnel support toward BMM objectives. This collaborative approach would ensure joint ownership and accountability, with both parties working together to achieve the goals and ensure sustainability. Additionally, capacity-building initiatives should be embedded within national institutions to institutionalize knowledge transfer. Formal communication channels with stakeholders could be strengthened to reduce delays. Given that Phase IV will likely be the final phase of the BMM programme, the focus should be on consolidating existing achievements rather than launching new lengthy policy initiatives. This approach will ensure resources are used effectively, maximize impact, and maintain continuity in policy implementation.

Section 5 describes the recommendations below in more detail and offers a list of actions for their implementation:

- **Recommendation 1:** Maintain a strong internal coordination structure and retain qualified staff to ensure efficiency and effective implementation of activities under BMM Phase IV.
- **Recommendation 2:** Enhance internal cross-country cooperation and synergies with implementing partners
- **Recommendation 3:** Ensure continuity between BMM programme phases.
- **Recommendation 4:** Strengthen procurement and financial coordination to streamline processes and prevent delays.
- **Recommendation 5:** Strengthen national ownership, commitment, and capacities.
- **Recommendation 6:** For BMM Phase IV, finalize ongoing policy processes and consolidate established activities instead of starting new lengthy initiatives, ensuring regional and cross-border initiatives are prioritized.